

George Washington (1789–1797): As the first president, he set the foundational precedents for the executive branch. He signed the Judiciary Act of 1789, which established the federal court system and the Supreme Court. In 1794, Washington asserted federal authority by using military force to suppress the Whiskey Rebellion in Pennsylvania, proving the new government could enforce its laws. His foreign policy was defined by the Proclamation of Neutrality (1793) regarding the French Revolution and the controversial Jay Treaty (1795) with Great Britain, which normalized trade but angered Jeffersonian Republicans. In his 1796 Farewell Address, he famously warned the nation against the dangers of political factions and permanent foreign alliances.

John Adams (1797–1801): A Federalist, his presidency was dominated by international tensions with France, leading to the undeclared naval "Quasi-War." The conflict was eventually resolved through the Treaty of Mortefontaine in 1800. Domestically, Adams faced intense criticism for signing the Alien and Sedition Acts of 1798, which restricted speech and immigrant rights in the name of national security. Just before leaving office, he signed the Judiciary Act of 1801, known as the "Midnight Judges Act," to entrench Federalist power in the courts.

Thomas Jefferson (1801–1809): A Democratic-Republican, he oversaw a massive expansion of U.S. territory with the Louisiana Purchase in 1803, buying the land from France for \$15 million despite his own strict constructionist views. He commissioned the Lewis and Clark Expedition (1804–1806) to explore this new territory. His second term was marred by the Embargo Act of 1807, which economically devastated the U.S. by banning trade with warring European powers. He also signed the Act Prohibiting Importation of Slaves, which took effect in 1808.

James Madison (1809–1817): He guided the United States through the War of 1812 against Great Britain, a conflict over maritime rights that saw the burning of Washington D.C. The war ended with the Treaty of Ghent in 1814, restoring pre-war borders. Following the war, Madison shifted his political stance to support a stronger central economy, chartering the Second Bank of the United States in 1816. He also replaced the failed Embargo Act with the Non-Intercourse Act of 1809 to attempt to leverage trade against Britain and France.

James Monroe (1817–1825): His presidency is known as the "Era of Good Feelings" due to the temporary collapse of partisan opposition. He signed the Missouri Compromise in 1820, admitting Missouri as a slave state and Maine as a free state while banning slavery north of the 36°30' parallel. His most lasting legacy is the Monroe Doctrine of 1823, which declared the Western Hemisphere off-limits to European colonization. He also secured the acquisition of Florida from Spain via the Adams-Onís Treaty of 1819.

John Quincy Adams (1825–1829): He won the presidency after a controversial election decided by the House of Representatives, leading to accusations of a "Corrupt Bargain" with Henry Clay. He was a proponent of the "American System," aggressively pushing for federally funded infrastructure like roads and canals. His presidency was politically damaged by the Tariff of 1828, known as the "Tariff of Abominations," which protected Northern industry but severely hurt the Southern economy.

Andrew Jackson (1829–1837): He championed the "common man" and greatly expanded executive power. He signed the Indian Removal Act of 1830, leading to the forced displacement of tribes known as the Trail of Tears. Jackson waged a political war against the Second Bank of the United States, vetoing its recharter in 1832 and withdrawing federal funds. He also faced the Nullification Crisis with South Carolina, threatening military force to uphold federal tariffs. His economic policies, specifically the Specie Circular of 1836, contributed to the subsequent financial panic.

Martin Van Buren (1837–1841): His single term was defined by the Panic of 1837, a severe economic depression. He attempted to stabilize the economy through the Independent Treasury Act of 1840, which kept government funds separate from state banks. His administration also dealt with the Amistad Case in 1839, initially favoring the extradition of mutinous Africans before the Supreme Court ruled in their favor.

William Henry Harrison (1841): He holds the record for the shortest presidency, dying of pneumonia just 31 days after his inauguration. His death sparked a constitutional crisis regarding the succession of power, which was resolved when Vice President John Tyler assumed the full office.

John Tyler (1841–1845): Dubbed "His Accidency," he was expelled from the Whig party for vetoing their legislation. His most significant achievement was the Annexation of Texas in 1845, signed just days before he left office. He also settled the northern border dispute with Canada through the Webster-Ashburton Treaty of 1842.

James K. Polk (1845–1849): He presided over a period of massive territorial expansion. He led the U.S. into the Mexican-American War (1846–1848), which resulted in the Treaty of Guadalupe Hidalgo and the acquisition of the American Southwest. He also settled the Oregon boundary dispute with Britain via the Oregon Treaty of 1846. Domestically, he lowered trade barriers with the Walker Tariff of 1846.

Zachary Taylor (1849–1850): A war hero, his short presidency was consumed by the debate over slavery in the new territories. He signed the Clayton-Bulwer Treaty of 1850 with Britain regarding Central American canals. He died suddenly in office in July 1850, having opposed the compromise measures that would later pass under his successor.

Millard Fillmore (1850–1853): He assumed the presidency upon Taylor's death and signed the Compromise of 1850. This package of bills admitted California as a free state but included the strict Fugitive Slave Act, which inflamed abolitionist sentiment. In foreign policy, he dispatched Commodore Matthew Perry in 1853 to force the opening of trade relations with isolationist Japan.

Franklin Pierce (1853–1857): He signed the controversial Kansas-Nebraska Act of 1854, which repealed the Missouri Compromise and allowed territories to decide on slavery via popular sovereignty, triggering the violence of "Bleeding Kansas." His administration acquired land for a southern railroad route through the Gadsden Purchase of 1853. His reputation suffered severely after the leak of the Ostend Manifesto, which proposed seizing Cuba from Spain.

James Buchanan (1857–1861): His presidency preceded the Civil War. He actively lobbied the Supreme Court to issue the broad, pro-slavery ruling in *Dred Scott v. Sandford* (1857). He supported the pro-slavery Lecompton Constitution for Kansas, splitting his party. When seven states seceded following Lincoln's election, Buchanan declared secession illegal but claimed the federal government lacked the constitutional authority to stop it.

Abraham Lincoln (1861–1865): He led the nation through the American Civil War to preserve the Union. He issued the Emancipation Proclamation in 1863, freeing slaves in Confederate territories, and pushed for the 13th Amendment to abolish slavery permanently. Domestically, he signed the Homestead Act and the Morrill Land-Grant Acts in 1862 to encourage western settlement and education. He also authorized the First Transcontinental Railroad via the Pacific Railway Acts. He was assassinated in April 1865.

Andrew Johnson (1865–1869): He clashed with Radical Republicans over Reconstruction, favoring leniency toward the South. He vetoed the Civil Rights Act of 1866, but Congress overrode him—the first time this occurred on a major bill. His violation of the Tenure of Office Act led to his impeachment in 1868, though he survived removal by a single vote. His administration also purchased Alaska from Russia in 1867.

Ulysses S. Grant (1869–1877): His presidency focused on enforcing civil rights during Reconstruction. He signed the Enforcement Acts and the Civil Rights Act of 1875 to combat the Ku Klux Klan. The 15th Amendment, prohibiting voting discrimination based on race, was ratified during his tenure. However, his administration was plagued by corruption scandals like the Credit Mobilier and the Whiskey Ring. The Panic of 1873 triggered a severe economic depression during his second term.

Rutherford B. Hayes (1877–1881): He took office following the Compromise of 1877, which resolved a disputed election in exchange for ending military Reconstruction in the South. He navigated the Great Railroad Strike of 1877 using federal troops. His administration also saw the passage of the Bland-Allison Act over his veto, which reintroduced silver coinage. Hayes attempted early civil service reform by banning political assessments for federal employees.

James A. Garfield (1881): His brief presidency was marked by his battle against the "Star Route" postal corruption rings. He was shot by a disgruntled office-seeker named Charles Guiteau just four months into his term and died in September 1881.

Chester A. Arthur (1881–1885): He surprised critics by signing the Pendleton Civil Service Reform Act of 1883, which mandated that federal jobs be awarded based on merit rather than patronage. He also signed the Chinese Exclusion Act of 1882, banning Chinese laborers. Arthur is credited with beginning the modernization of the U.S. Navy, commissioning the first steel vessels.

Grover Cleveland (1885–1889, 1893–1897): He is the only president to serve two non-consecutive terms. In his first term, he signed the Interstate Commerce Act of 1887 to regulate railroads and the Dawes Act, which broke up tribal lands. He was known for vetoing hundreds of fraudulent pension bills. His second term was defined by the Panic of 1893; in response, he

repealed the Sherman Silver Purchase Act to protect gold reserves. He also deployed troops to break the Pullman Strike in 1894.

Benjamin Harrison (1889–1893): He signed the Sherman Antitrust Act of 1890, the first federal law limiting monopolies. His administration passed the McKinley Tariff, raising rates to historic highs, and the Sherman Silver Purchase Act. He also signed the Dependent and Disability Pension Act, which expanded veteran benefits and depleted the federal budget surplus.

William McKinley (1897–1901): He led the U.S. into the Spanish-American War in 1898, resulting in the acquisition of Puerto Rico, Guam, and the Philippines, as well as the annexation of Hawaii. He signed the Gold Standard Act of 1900, cementing gold as the basis for the currency. His administration promoted the Open Door Policy to ensure trade access in China. McKinley was assassinated in 1901.

Theodore Roosevelt (1901–1909): He championed a "Square Deal" of conservation, corporate control, and consumer protection. He signed the Pure Food and Drug Act and the Meat Inspection Act in 1906. He aggressively used the Sherman Act to break up monopolies and strengthened the ICC via the Hepburn Act. Internationally, he facilitated the construction of the Panama Canal and issued the Roosevelt Corollary to the Monroe Doctrine, asserting the U.S. right to intervene in Latin America.

William Howard Taft (1909–1913): He continued antitrust efforts, initiating more suits in four years than Roosevelt did in seven. He signed the Mann-Elkins Act to regulate telecommunications but angered Progressives by signing the Payne-Aldrich Tariff. Under his administration, the 16th Amendment authorizing a federal income tax was passed by Congress and ratified. He practiced "Dollar Diplomacy" to extend U.S. influence through investment.

Woodrow Wilson (1913–1921): He implemented the "New Freedom" agenda, establishing the Federal Reserve System in 1913 and the Federal Trade Commission in 1914. He signed the Clayton Antitrust Act to strengthen labor rights. Wilson led the U.S. into World War I in 1917 and proposed the Fourteen Points for peace, including the League of Nations. His administration suppressed dissent through the Espionage and Sedition Acts and saw the ratification of the 19th Amendment, granting women the vote.

Warren G. Harding (1921–1923): He campaigned on a "Return to Normalcy." He signed the Budget and Accounting Act of 1921, creating the modern budget process. His administration hosted the Washington Naval Conference to limit arms. However, his presidency is best remembered for the Teapot Dome Scandal, where cabinet members accepted bribes for leasing oil reserves. Harding died in office in 1923.

Calvin Coolidge (1923–1929): He presided over a period of economic growth known as "Coolidge Prosperity." He signed the Revenue Acts of 1924, 1926, and 1928, drastically reducing income taxes. He also signed the Immigration Act of 1924, which imposed strict quotas on immigration. In foreign policy, his administration negotiated the Kellogg-Briand Pact of 1928, renouncing war as a national policy instrument.

Herbert Hoover (1929–1933): He took office just months before the Stock Market Crash of 1929. His signing of the Smoot-Hawley Tariff in 1930 is widely blamed for worsening the Great Depression. While he eventually established the Reconstruction Finance Corporation in 1932 to bail out banks and local governments, his response was seen as insufficient. He also signed the Norris-La Guardia Act, which outlawed "yellow-dog" labor contracts.

Franklin D. Roosevelt (1933–1945): He implemented the "New Deal" to combat the Great Depression. Key legislation included the Social Security Act of 1935, the National Labor Relations Act (Wagner Act), and the Glass-Steagall Act establishing the FDIC. He led the U.S. through World War II, authorizing the Lend-Lease Act in 1941 and the controversial internment of Japanese Americans. He was the only president elected to four terms.

Harry S. Truman (1945–1953): He made the decision to use atomic bombs on Japan in 1945. His "Truman Doctrine" established the policy of containment against Soviet expansion, supported by the Marshall Plan's aid to Europe and the formation of NATO in 1949. Domestically, he desegregated the military via Executive Order 9981. He also sent U.S. troops into the Korean War in 1950.

Dwight D. Eisenhower (1953–1961): He signed the Federal-Aid Highway Act of 1956, creating the Interstate Highway System. He enforced school desegregation by sending troops to Little Rock, Arkansas, in 1957 and signed the Civil Rights Act of 1957. In response to the Soviet Sputnik launch, he signed the National Defense Education Act. In his farewell address, he famously warned of the "Military-Industrial Complex."

John F. Kennedy (1961–1963): He faced the height of Cold War tensions, including the failed Bay of Pigs invasion and the Cuban Missile Crisis of 1962. He established the Peace Corps and signed the Equal Pay Act of 1963. He also negotiated the Nuclear Test Ban Treaty. Kennedy was assassinated in Dallas in November 1963.

Lyndon B. Johnson (1963–1969): He enacted the "Great Society" reforms. He signed the landmark Civil Rights Act of 1964 and the Voting Rights Act of 1965. His administration created Medicare and Medicaid and reformed immigration via the Act of 1965. However, his presidency was consumed by the escalation of the Vietnam War following the Gulf of Tonkin Resolution.

Richard Nixon (1969–1974): He created the Environmental Protection Agency (EPA) by executive order and signed the Clean Air Act of 1970. He achieved a diplomatic breakthrough by opening relations with China in 1972 and signing the SALT I arms treaty. He ended the gold standard in 1971. His presidency ended in resignation in 1974 due to the Watergate scandal and ensuing cover-up.

Gerald Ford (1974–1977): He is the only president to serve without being elected to either the presidency or vice presidency. He controversially pardoned Richard Nixon in 1974. He signed the Helsinki Accords in 1975 to ease Cold War tensions and the Education for All Handicapped Children Act.

Jimmy Carter (1977–1981): He brokered the Camp David Accords between Egypt and Israel in 1978. Domestically, he created the Departments of Energy and Education. He oversaw the deregulation of the airline, trucking, and rail industries. His presidency was struggled with stagflation and the Iran Hostage Crisis, where American diplomats were held for 444 days.

Ronald Reagan (1981–1989): He implemented "Reaganomics," characterized by the massive tax cuts of the Economic Recovery Tax Act of 1981 and the Tax Reform Act of 1986. He increased military spending and proposed the Strategic Defense Initiative ("Star Wars"). He signed the Immigration Reform and Control Act of 1986. His second term was marred by the Iran-Contra Affair, though he achieved the INF Treaty with the Soviet Union in 1987.

George H.W. Bush (1989–1993): He oversaw the end of the Cold War and the dissolution of the Soviet Union. He organized the international coalition for the Gulf War in 1991 to liberate Kuwait. Domestically, he signed the Americans with Disabilities Act (ADA) in 1990 and the Clean Air Act Amendments. He lost reelection largely due to breaking his "no new taxes" pledge during 1990 budget negotiations.

Bill Clinton (1993–2001): He signed the North American Free Trade Agreement (NAFTA) in 1993 and the Violent Crime Control and Law Enforcement Act of 1994. He worked with a Republican Congress to pass the Welfare Reform Act of 1996. His administration achieved federal budget surpluses in the late 1990s. He was impeached in 1998 over the Lewinsky scandal but was acquitted by the Senate.

George W. Bush (2001–2009): His presidency was defined by the September 11, 2001 terrorist attacks. In response, he created the Department of Homeland Security, signed the PATRIOT Act, and launched wars in Afghanistan and Iraq. Domestically, he passed the No Child Left Behind Act for education reform and the PEPFAR program to combat global HIV/AIDS. His term ended amidst the 2008 financial crisis, prompting the TARP bank bailout.

Barack Obama (2009–2017): He signed the Affordable Care Act ("Obamacare") in 2010, significantly expanding health coverage. He passed the Dodd-Frank Act to reform Wall Street and the American Recovery and Reinvestment Act to counter the recession. In foreign policy, he authorized the raid that killed Osama bin Laden and entered the Paris Climate Agreement and the Iran Nuclear Deal. He utilized executive actions to create the DACA program for young immigrants.

Donald Trump (2017–2021): In his first term, he signed the Tax Cuts and Jobs Act of 2017 and appointed three conservative Supreme Court justices. He passed the First Step Act for criminal justice reform and established the Space Force. His administration withdrew the U.S. from the Paris Agreement and the Iran Nuclear Deal. He was impeached twice, first regarding Ukraine and second regarding the January 6 Capitol attack.

Joe Biden (2021–2025): He signed the American Rescue Plan to address the COVID-19 pandemic and the bipartisan Infrastructure Investment and Jobs Act. His administration passed the Inflation Reduction Act in 2022, focusing on climate energy and drug pricing, and the CHIPS and Science Act. Internationally, he oversaw the withdrawal from Afghanistan and led the

coalition supporting Ukraine against Russia. He withdrew from the 2024 election race late in his term.

Donald Trump (2025–Present): Following his re-election as the 47th president in 2024, he became the second president to serve two non-consecutive terms. His second administration quickly established the Department of Government Efficiency (DOGE) to audit federal agencies and reclassify civil servants. In July 2025, he signed the "One Big Beautiful Bill Act," which extended previous tax cuts and introduced federal tax credits for school choice. He reinstated strict border policies via executive orders on his first day and withdrew the U.S. from the Paris Climate Agreement for a second time.